



28. DRIVES RESULTS

Consistently achieving results, even under tough circumstances.

Driving results is an overall achievement mindset, a bias for action, an eagerness to take the initiative. People who drive for results infuse their teams and organizations with a sense of urgency. They help create a culture where organizational performance is always top of mind. Results might be quantifiable—measured in terms of P&L, sales growth, customer satisfaction ratings, new products launched. Or results may be qualitative—an enhanced reputation among customers, a more vibrant brand that attracts customers and employee talent. In successful organizations, the efforts of individuals, teams, functions, departments, and business units are aligned around these objectives. Driving results means communicating a vision, setting priorities, developing and executing plans that achieve the desired outcome—for the organization and the world. As a leader, you *must* be willing to act and follow through to drive results.



*"If my mind can conceive it,
and my heart can believe it,
I know I can achieve it!"*

Jesse Jackson – American civil rights activist

Drives results is in the **Results** factor (II) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster F, **Focusing on performance**, along with *Ensures* accountability (1). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in that chapter to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Has a strong bottom-line orientation.**
- ★ **Persists in accomplishing objectives despite obstacles and setbacks.**
- ★ **Has a track record of exceeding goals successfully.**
- ★ **Pushes self and helps others achieve results.**

Less skilled

- Is reluctant to push for results.
- Does the least to get by.
- Is an inconsistent performer.
- Gives up easily; doesn't go back with different strategies for the third and fourth try.
- Often misses deadlines.
- Procrastinates around whatever gets in the way.

Talented

- Sets aggressive goals and has high standards.
- Is consistently one of the top performers.
- Pursues everything with energy, drive, and the need to finish.
- Persists in the face of challenges and setbacks.
- Always keeps the end in sight; puts in extra effort to meet deadlines.

Overused skill

- Goes for results at all costs without appropriate concern for people, teams, due process, or possibly norms and ethics.
- May be so deadline oriented that he/she pushes to get something done rather than taking the time to do it right.
- Even in the face of near insurmountable obstacles, sticks with the effort beyond reason.
- Puts too much pressure on self and others to achieve the impossible.
- May not celebrate and share successes.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with *Drives* results. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Loses focus.
- Disorganized.
- Not strategic.

- Procrastinates.
- Sets unrealistic expectations.
- Poor planner.
- Burned out.
- Afraid of mistakes.
- Lacks commitment and accountability.



Brain booster

So driven that you can't relax? For the highest achievers, it can be hard to stop and take a break, but it turns out that rest and relaxation is exactly what helps us maintain high levels of achievement. This may feel like a paradox, but conduct your own experiment to see for yourself. Research has shown that short naps improve the vigilance and judgment of air traffic controllers. Getting a full night's sleep improves memory. Staying unplugged on vacation decreases the likelihood that you'll leave your company. Stepping away, switching off, relaxing, and protecting your workout time all contribute to higher productivity and better job performance. While wishing for more hours in your day is futile, wishing for more energy during your day is achievable.

Tips to develop *Drives* results

1. **Have a big idea? Convert it to action.** Ever get on board with a big initiative, only to run out of steam? Create inspiring plans in an off-site and then forget about them? Or set an audacious goal in January and lose track of it by February? Big ideas produce big results over the long haul. In fact, they can be downright

transformative. But to see results, you need to translate ideas into action. If you are part of something big, keep it front of mind by making it visible. Post a photo or other reminder on your screensaver so you see it every time you open your laptop. Create a visual model or time line and share it with others. If it involves the whole organization, get HR, marketing, communications, or other relevant groups involved. Create a communications plan. Put time on the calendar to get things moving. A vision is just a good idea until you take action.

2. **Not bold enough? Take reasonable risks.** Won't take a risk? Micromanaging to avoid mistakes? Running another analysis of last month's figures? Rethinking decisions? If this is you, practice pushing yourself forward. Sometimes producing results involves taking chances and trying bold new initiatives. Doing those things leads to more misfires and mistakes but sometimes better results. Treat any mistakes or failures as chances to learn. Nothing ventured, nothing gained. Up your risk comfort. To get results, you need to keep things moving. Making decisions. Approving plans. Start small so you can recover more quickly. See how creative and innovative you can be. Let go of perfection and aim for excellence. Satisfy yourself; people will always say it should have been done differently. Listen to them, but be skeptical. Ask yourself what's at stake. And what's the worst that can happen. Then turn the question around: What good things will *not* happen if you fail to act? Allow reasonable time to consider options, then make the best decision possible. Conduct a postmortem immediately after finishing. This will indicate to all that you're open to continuous improvement whether the result was stellar or not.

3. **Procrastinator? Start now.** Are you a lifelong procrastinator? Do you perform best in crises and under impossible deadlines? Do you wait until the last possible moment? If you do, you may miss deadlines and performance targets. You might not produce consistent results. Some of your work will be marginal because you didn't have the time to do it right. You settled for a B when you could have gotten an A if you had one more day to work on it. And you might be causing yourself and your teammates unnecessary stress. Save "crisis mode" for your own time. When others are depending on you, get going. Start earlier. Try doing 10% of each task immediately after it is assigned so you can better gauge what it is going to take to finish the rest. Divide tasks and assignments into thirds and schedule time to do them spaced over the delivery period. Let others know how you are progressing. Always leave more time than you think it's going to take.
4. **Overwhelmed? Focus on priorities.** You're already working at top speed on a full schedule. Then your boss asks you to take on something new—right now. You feel like you need to go in eight different directions and don't know where to start. Before you panic, do some planning. What's mission-critical? What are the three to five things that most need to get done to achieve your goals? Effective performers typically spend about half their time on a few mission-critical priorities. Don't get diverted by trivia and things you like doing but aren't tied to the bottom line. When you've laid out your top priorities, identify a few critical action steps that will move you forward on each one. Notice what is demanding immediate attention—and what is actually already on track. Put some space on your calendar to take care of what is

important but not urgent now. Then take care of the urgent. This planning will take just a few minutes and will get you back on track. If you're still uptight, ask for help. And remember to manage your expectations of yourself: as good as you may be, you can't be in two places at once.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Driscoll, M. (2013, July 18). Research: Why companies keep getting blind-sided by risk. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Giang, V. (2012, March 18). *15 Ways to stop procrastinating right now*. Business Insider.

Llopis, G. (2013, April 1). The 12 things that successfully convert a great idea into a reality. *Forbes*.

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Taking initiative: Making things happen in the workplace*. Mind Tools.

- 5. Problem getting work done through others? Focus on the fundamentals.** Many people can produce results themselves but struggle to make the transition to getting results from the team. Having trouble getting your team to work with you to get the results you need? Have the resources and the people but things just don't run well? Maybe you do too much of the work yourself. You don't delegate or empower. You don't communicate well. Struggle to motivate. Plan poorly. Find prioritizing difficult. You may need to learn the basics of delegation and good management. To let go of doing it all yourself. To learn to show others what you want done—and let them do it. To paint a clear picture of what is important and why. Delegation is a complex

skill. It takes effort to show others what you want. But it pays off over time. The team will become stronger. Results will be better. Read *Becoming a Manager* by Linda A. Hill. Learn from others around you who delegate well.

- 6. Trouble getting buy-in? Listen before you act.** Focused on action? Eager to get started? Anxious to get results? These are great qualities for getting to the bottom line. But if you're driving results through others, you need to slow down and include them in your thinking. People can't follow you if they don't know where you are going, and why. Give them the big picture of what needs to happen. Invite them to flesh out ideas and plans. Work with them to define plans and expectations. Help them prioritize their own efforts. Start with a brainstorming session. "Here's what we need to do. How can we do this?" Collaborate on creating a plan. Or hand it off to them. Check in. Stay involved to see how things are going. Let them know how their efforts align with the organizational goals.

- 7. People not committed? Set stretch goals and stay involved.** High expectations are great. But if goals are perceived as unachievable, people become skeptical and discouraged. They give up and performance lags. Or, if goals are too low, boredom sets in and performance lags. People lose interest and end up underperforming. Setting stretching but achievable goals shows confidence. It creates optimism and an expectation for success. But don't just set goals. Ask what is needed to get there. Get the resources and support you need—and set checkpoints along the way to measure progress. Give yourself and others as much feedback as you can. Get buy-in. Recognize improvement.

Celebrate success. Then agree on next steps to even higher performance.

8. Group not performing? Address team dynamics. Leading a stalled project? In danger of missing the goal? Delivering subpar performance? Every group and team is made up of individuals. Some who may be giving more than others. Some who may be willing but struggling. Some may have “checked out” for reasons of their own. If this is happening, assess the team as a whole. Does it have an agreed-upon goal? The right mix of skills? The resources it needs? Adequate support from the organization? Make the changes you need to make to ensure results are achieved. Look at individuals. Do you need to switch out some team members or bring in new skills? Encourage different working relationships? Stimulate new collaborations? Address conflict? Figure out what’s not working and make it right. Ask HR for help or bring in a team consultant if you are really stumped.

9. Getting resistance? Deal with objections. It’s your job to drive a major change initiative. You’ve got your resources, your time line, your plans. Everything looks good. Until a key group or person raises objections. Why are we doing this? What will this cost? Why are we changing what we’ve done for 20 years? The best change leaders don’t get derailed by pushback. They anticipate resistance. They are equipped to handle the heat of controversy. They allow time to hear objections. Individual meetings. Town halls. Phone conferences. They answer objections and make course corrections. But they don’t lose sight of the endgame. The vision. The results. Encourage more objections. If you sense people are holding back, get concerns out on the table. Ask for

specifics. Dig deep. Get to the root of the resistance. Understand what’s behind the dissent. See it from their point of view. If you were in their shoes, what would you need to hear to be converted?

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Gleeson, B. (2012, December 28). Setting stretch goals: All in, all the time. *Inc.*

Hill, L., & Lineback, K. (2012, April 3). Good managers lead through a team. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network.*

Russell, N. S. (2013, February 8). Six ways to get things done when you’re not the boss. *Forbes.*

Sevier, R. A. (2006, September). Moving a team forward. *University Business.*

10. Derailed by the unexpected? Define and address the problem.

You’re working hard, focused on getting things done. Then something unexpected happens. A system glitch destroys last night’s work. An important meeting gets cancelled. Maybe you get stuck in traffic and arrive at the office two hours late. When you are thrown off track by the unexpected, you have two choices. You can either tense up, throw up your hands, snap at a few coworkers, and generally make the situation worse, or you can take a breath, stay calm, and find a way around or through the situation. Pick up the phone, get on e-mail, reach out to others, and work the problem. Use your brain, use your resources. Envision a good outcome. Shift your attitude from “Why is this happening to me?” to “Interesting development. Let’s see what we can do with it.”

- 11. Disorganized? Use systems to stay on track.** Running late? Missed a phone call? Lost a critical e-mail? When you're going in more than one direction, the occasional slip-up is inevitable. But you can't consistently deliver results if you can't stay on top of the details. Use systems to have a fighting chance of completing things on time and within budget. Log contact info into your phone or e-mail system. Deal with e-mail two to three times a day. Answer, forward, or act on anything you can. File the rest in project folders and put time on your calendar for follow-up. Have a to-do list or system for immediate tasks. Look at it at the beginning or end of the day. Add new items; delete those you've completed. Learn some basic Excel skills to create simple project sheets. Use just one calendar. Color code your files and tasks. Use mobile technology to access your e-mail and calendar on the go. Learn to live without paper. Back up your laptop. Remember that when it comes to being organized, less is more.
- 12. Tempted to quit before the end? Refocus and stick with it.** It may be tempting to reduce your efforts when the end is in sight. After all, your customers have been delighted with the new products. The economy has run strong all year. Things are going well, so results are in the bag—right? Not necessarily. Surprises happen. Contracts get cancelled. Opportunities and sure things fizzle out. Markets crash. If you find your attention flagging, refocus. Winning teams play with the same intensity the whole game, no matter the score. Driving for results means not quitting before the end. Getting results means sticking with the project until it is completed successfully. Keep up a review of what has been done, what remains to be done, and where results will come from. Be persistent. Follow through on every task. Sometimes

you'll head off a disaster. Sometimes you'll find an unexpected late win. Check the details. It's not over until it's over.

- 13. Lost in the detail? Focus on the essentials.** Good with the detail? Pride yourself on your expertise? Remember names, dates, and places? Can relate the history of any product your company ever produced? Have the answer to any question? Being this detail oriented doesn't mean you're the quickest to get results. While you're stuck in what you know, the people around you want to move on. To create the next generation of products. To adopt some new ideas. To get up to speed, you don't need to abandon valuable detail. But you do need to streamline your thinking—and your communication. Focus on the endpoint and ask yourself, "How much detail is needed to paint the picture and move us forward?" Use what is needed now. Archive or jettison the rest.
- 14. Driving too hard? Learn to manage stress.** Pride yourself on exceeding goals? Push yourself every day to produce? Always ready for a challenge? Individual responses to stress vary. But for most people, driving for results day after day, quarter after quarter, year after year is stressful. If you're close to burnout or if people can't keep up with you, you're overdoing it. Sustainable performance requires rest and recovery. Athletes train hard, then enjoy the off-season. Performance will improve if you disconnect once in a while. Use your commute to work to get perspective. Enjoy friends and family. Make personal connections at work. Stop to celebrate wins. Learn to take pride in your great results, but balance action with recovery. Take a time out.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Grant Halvorson, H. (2011, June 22). How to become a great finisher. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Mayo Clinic Staff. (2011, May 28). *Positive thinking: Reduce stress by eliminating negative self-talk*. Mayo Clinic.

Stolovitsky, N. (2010, August 4). *Planning for the unplanned: Including risk in your project management strategy*. Genius Project.

Wilkinson, M. (2010, June 18). *Why perseverance is an essential quality to possess in the workplace*. Career Path 360.

Job assignments

- Lead a team in launching a new product or service with a large potential impact on the business. Involve them in thinking through how to maximize benefit to the business.
- Manage the successful installation of a new process or system under a tight deadline. Secure the right support and build a strong sense of commitment to making it a success.
- Lead a stalled project to successful completion within the next few weeks. Identify the issues and generate solutions to move it forward.
- Develop an actionable time line to improve performance in a group that has lost momentum. Dig deep for the reasons and take action to get them back on track.
- Create, champion, and track a fundraising campaign with a clear financial goal. Get creative about how it can be exceeded.

Take time to reflect...

If the goal ahead seems unattainable...

...then make it your mission to get others on board. Securing the commitment of the team is critical. Clarify the goal. Sell the vision. Share the plan. Define roles. Turn them loose.

If you've been pushing hard and don't see an end in sight...

...then remember the goal you are striving toward. Celebrate what you've achieved so far. Regroup. Plunge back in with renewed vigor.

If you can't face those last few steps of the task...

...then ask yourself what's holding you back. Inspiration and aspiration are just the start. Action is what will take you across the finish line. Craft a plan. Carve out the time. Focus on the goal in sight.

*"One never notices what has been done;
one can only see what remains to be done."*

Marie Curie – Polish and naturalized-French physicist and chemist



Learn more about **Drives** results

Baldoni, J. (2006). *How great leaders get great results*. New York, NY: McGraw-Hill.

Hiam, A. (2003). *Motivational management: Inspiring your people for maximum performance*. New York, NY: AMACOM.

- Meier, J. D. (2010). *Getting results the agile way: A personal results system for work and life*. Bellevue, WA: Innovation Playhouse, LLC.
- Myers, B. (2012). *Take the lead: Motivate, inspire, and bring out the best in yourself and everyone around you*. New York, NY: Atria Paperback.
- Thomas, K. W. (2009). *Intrinsic motivation at work: What really drives employee engagement* (2nd ed.). San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers.



Deep dive learning resource links

- Driscoll, M. (2013, July 18). Research: Why companies keep getting blind-sided by risk. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2013/07/research-why-companies-get-blindsided/>
- Giang, V. (2012, March 18). *15 Ways to stop procrastinating right now*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://www.businessinsider.com/15-ways-to-stop-procrastinating-right-now-2012-3?op=1>
- Gleeson, B. (2012, December 28). Setting stretch goals: All in, all the time. *Inc.* Retrieved from <http://www.inc.com/brent-gleeson/setting-stretch-goals.html>
- Grant Halvorson, H. (2011, June 22). How to become a great finisher. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2011/06/how-to-become-a-great-finisher/>
- Hill, L., & Lineback, K. (2012, April 3). Good managers lead through a team. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2012/04/good-managers-lead-through-a-t/>
- Llopis, G. (2013, April 1). The 12 things that successfully convert a great idea into a reality. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/glennllopis/2013/04/01/12-things-successfully-convert-a-great-idea-into-a-reality/>
- Mayo Clinic Staff. (2011, May 28). *Positive thinking: Reduce stress by eliminating negative self-talk*. Mayo Clinic. Retrieved from <http://www.mayoclinic.org/positive-thinking/art-20043950>
- Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Taking initiative: Making things happen in the workplace*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from <http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/initiative.htm>
- Russell, N. S. (2013, February 8). Six ways to get things done when you're not the boss. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/deborahljacobs/2013/02/08/six-ways-to-get-things-done-when-youre-not-the-boss/>
- Sevier, R. A. (2006, September). Moving a team forward. *University Business*. Retrieved from <http://www.universitybusiness.com/article/moving-team-forward>
- Stolovitsky, N. (2010, August 4). *Planning for the unplanned: Including risk in your project management strategy*. Genius Project. Retrieved from <http://www.geniusproject.com/blog/pm-best-practices/planning-for-the-unplanned-including-risk-in-your-project-management-strategy/>
- Wilkinson, M. (2010, June 18). *Why perseverance is an essential quality to possess in the workplace*. Career Path 360. Retrieved from

<http://www.careerpath360.com/index.php/why-perseverance-is-an-essential-quality-to-possess-in-the-workplace-4-9318/>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore *Drives* results further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Effectively reducing stress at work.
- Getting work done through others.
- Planning for unexpected problems at work.
- Risk management.
- Setting stretch goals for employees.
- Turning an idea into reality.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



29. DEMONSTRATES SELF-AWARENESS

Using a combination of feedback and reflection to gain productive insight into personal strengths and weaknesses.

Self-awareness, the ability to clearly assess your own capabilities, gives a foundation upon which to grow, develop, and take on new challenges. Deploying yourself against life and work is greatly helped by really knowing what you're good at, average at, and bad at, what you're untested in, and what you overdo or overuse. It is not a new concept—it was Socrates who said "Know thyself." The fact that over 2,000 years later we're still figuring out how to be more self-aware is an indication of how challenging it is for us to see ourselves as we are. Self-aware people are able to connect the external perspective—how they are perceived by others—with the internal—how they see themselves. And that can be uncomfortable. But with great risk comes the potential for great reward—both for yourself personally and for your organization. That is, if you take action. Just increasing your self-awareness is not enough. You must do something with that knowledge, if it is to have an impact. Accepting that you have changes to make is your choice—it's up to no one but you. That means aligning your strengths and development areas with what's important for your career growth and deciding how to apply your increased self-awareness. Knowing how it can make you more effective and doing something about it.



*"The more you know yourself,
the more patience you have for what you see in others."*

Joan Erikson – Canadian psychologist

Demonstrates self-awareness is in the **Self** factor (IV) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster K, **Being open**, along with Self-development (30). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in that chapter to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Reflects on activities and impact on others.**
- ★ **Proactively seeks feedback without being defensive.**
- ★ **Is open to criticism and talking about shortcomings.**
- ★ **Admits mistakes and gains insight from experiences.**
- ★ **Knows strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and limits.**

Less skilled

- Doesn't reflect on past mistakes.
- Acts defensively when given feedback.
- Is unaware of own skills and interpersonal impact.
- Makes excuses and blames others.

Talented

- Seeks and acts on feedback from a wide variety of people.
- Willingly admits and takes responsibility for mistakes and shortcomings.
- Views criticism as helpful.
- Can articulate the causes behind own feelings and moods.

Overused skill

- Overthinks or overanalyzes feedback from others.
- May be self-critical to the point of risking credibility and appearing insecure.
- Spends too much time on building self-insight and not enough time on making meaningful changes to behavior or skills.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with *Demonstrates* self-awareness. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Arrogant.
- Defensive.

- Doesn't get any feedback.
- Doesn't know how to get feedback.
- Too much success.
- Blames others.
- Shuts down in the face of criticism.
- Spends too much time on reflection before acting.
- Sways too much based on feedback.
- Unable to learn from mistakes.
- Doesn't take the time to reflect on experience.
- Too modest.
- Too self-critical.



Brain booster

Your brain has an observer that sits above all the activity and notices, monitors, and directs your thinking. Sometimes the observer is in narrative mode and is processing memories, making plans, and interpreting information. Sometimes the observer is in sensation mode and is focusing on all of the information coming in to your senses in real time—including feelings, thoughts, and internal states. Being mindful and self-aware involves activating this observer, knowing whether you are in narrative or sensation mode, and consciously being able to shift between the two. Practice focusing your attention on one of your five senses. Observe the thoughts and interpretations that cross your mind. Practice noticing without judging. All of these exercises can help restructure your brain to make it easier to be aware of what you are feeling, experiencing, and thinking. And,

once you are aware, you have more control to decide what you will do, how you will interpret something, and how you will respond.

Tips to develop *Demonstrates self-awareness*

- 1. Not sure how others see you? Get feedback.** People can be reluctant to give feedback, especially negative or corrective information. Generally, to get it, you must ask for it. Seeking negative feedback increases both the accuracy of our understanding and people's evaluation of our overall effectiveness. A person who wants to know the bad must be pretty good. People will increase their estimation of you as you seek out and accept more feedback. If people are reluctant to give criticism, help by making self-appraisal statements rather than asking questions. Saying, "I think I focus too much on operations and miss some of the larger strategic connections; what do you think?" is easier for most people to reply to than a question which asks them to volunteer this point.
- 2. Want to get the real story? Keep it confidential and balanced.** Confidential feedback, a private discussion, or a private 360 feedback tool tends to be more accurate than public feedback. Don't assume everything is OK just because you aren't getting feedback. For most of us, when people give us feedback in public, it's an excessively positive view. Don't get too comfortable with what people tell you in public settings. Use private feedback as a means to understand how others see you and to get the most accurate information. Try not to stack the deck, asking for feedback only from people you get along with or like most. The best way to get good feedback data is to choose wisely. Choose

people who are in the best position to observe your skills and capabilities, friendship or warm feelings aside.

- 3. Want a broader view of yourself? Seek feedback from more than one source.** Different people know about your performance in different areas. When asking for feedback, make sure you are involving people who see you from a variety of angles. It doesn't have to be a big production. Seek out feedback on a daily basis by asking others how they think things are going. Ask others what they'd like to see you continue. Do differently. Where you can improve. Bosses tend to know about your strategic grasp, selling-up skills, comfort around higher management, presentation of problems and solutions, clarity of thinking, team building, confronting and sizing up people skills. Customers will have a view on responsiveness, listening, quality orientation, problem-solving skills, understanding of their business needs, persuasiveness. Peers observe persuasion, selling, negotiation, listening to find common cause, keeping the interests of the organization in mind, follow-through on promises, and attention to give-and-take in 50/50 relationships. Direct reports know about your day-to-day behavior of leadership, management, team building, delegation, confronting, approachability, time use. When you get feedback, ask yourself if the person is in a position to know that about you. You may be the only one who doesn't know the truth about yourself. Other sources agree much more with one another about you than you will likely agree with any one of the sources. Even though your own view is important, don't accept it as fact until verified by more than one other person who should know.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Ask a Manager. (2011, March 9). *How can I get critical feedback?*

Askamanager.org.

Donnelly, T. (2010, August 10). How to get feedback from employees. *Inc.*

Gallo, A. (2012, May 15). How to get feedback when you're the boss. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network.*

- 4. Getting ruffled? Manage your response.** Sometimes feedback doesn't seem to fit and it's easy to become defensive or upset. Defensiveness is a major blockage to self-knowledge. When you respond in a defensive manner, people suspect you really can't take it, that you are defending against something, probably by blaming it on others or the job context. Defensive people get less feedback. To break this cycle, you will need to follow the rules of good listening. Work on keeping yourself in a calm state when getting negative feedback. Change your thinking. When getting the feedback, your only task is to accurately understand what people are trying to tell you. It is not your task at that point to accept or reject. That comes later. Mentally rehearse how you will calmly react to tough feedback situations before they happen. Develop automatic tactics to shut down or delay your usual emotional response. Some useful tactics are to slow down, take notes, ask clarifying questions, ask them for concrete examples, and thank them for telling you since you know it's not easy for them. While this may sound unfair, you should initially accept all feedback as accurate, even when you know it isn't. On those matters that really count, you can go back and fix it later.

- 5. Can't make sense of it? Analyze the feedback.** Too much information coming at you at once? You need to prioritize. Once you have understood the feedback, carry out the following exercise:

- (1) Write down all of the viewpoints on Post-it® Notes.
- (2) Create two categories: 1. The criticisms that are probably true of you. 2. The criticisms that are probably not true of you. Ask someone you trust who knows you well to help you so you don't delude yourself.
- (3) For those that are true, signal to the people who gave you the feedback that you have understood, think it was accurate, and will try to do something about it.
- (4) For those that are not true, re-sort the comments into criticisms that are important to you and those that are small and trivial or unimportant. Throw the unimportant ones away.
- (5) With those that are probably not true but important, re-sort them into:
 - (6) Career threatening—if people above me really thought this was true about me, my career would be damaged.
 - (7) Not career stopping. Throw the not-career-stopping pile away.
 - (8) With the remaining comments, review them with your boss and/or mentor to see what the general opinion is about you.
 - (9) This leaves you with two categories: those that people do believe—even though they are not true—and those they don't. Throw the don't-believe pile away.

(10) With the remaining pile, plot a strategy to convince people around you by deeds, not words, that those criticisms are untrue of you.

6. **Feeling overwhelmed? Think before you act.** Feel like you're constantly trying to change based on comments from others? Head spinning? Not sure which way to go? Developing your self-awareness means being open to feedback, but it can be exhausting, especially when it comes from various directions. It's a valuable source of information, so don't waste it, but think carefully how you use it. First, consider the source. Do you trust this person? Do you look up to them and value their opinion? Do you need to work with them on a regular basis? Second, get to the behavior. If feedback is too general, it is not helpful. Distill the comments down to the core behavior or message. What is it this person is trying to tell you? Third, reflect. Is this consistent with what you've heard in the past? Does it fit with what you know of yourself? Is it important? Even if it doesn't seem to be true, is there something here that needs attention? Fourth, decide. Do you want to do anything about it? You do have a choice, but think it through. The feedback was given for a reason. Understand it before you dismiss it. Decide to change? Make a plan. Decide to do nothing? Move on.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Robles, P. (2009, October 2). *How do you handle feedback?*
Ecoconsultancy.com.

Smith, J. (2013, January 29). How negative feedback can help your career. *Forbes*.

Wright, K. (2011, March 15). How to take feedback. *Psychology Today*.

7. **Come across as arrogant? Adopt some humility.** Arrogance is a major blockage to self-knowledge. Many people who have a towering strength or lots of success get little feedback and roll along until their careers get in trouble. They're so sure of themselves that often they're caught off guard. If you are viewed as arrogant, you may have to repeatedly ask for feedback, and when you get it, there may be some anger with it. Almost by definition, arrogant people overrate themselves in the eyes of others. Others who think you are arrogant might rate you lower than neutral observers. If you devalue others, they will return the insult. When others give you feedback, look at it as an opportunity to grow and develop. Feedback is a gift. If you don't appear to be genuinely interested in what others have to say to you, you risk cutting off the source. If their feedback falls on stony ground, why should they bother providing any more? By demonstrating openness to others' feedback, you're more likely to get more valuable feedback in the future.
8. **Got blind spots? Turn them into known weaknesses.** Blind spots are things you think you're good at, but others don't see it that way. They're an overestimation of your competence. The

thing that gets us into the most career trouble is a blind spot that matters. Better to have a known and admitted weakness. We know we are not good at it so we try harder, ask for help, delegate it, get a consultant, get a tutor, read a book, or loop around it. Ignorance is not bliss when it comes to blind spots. How do you identify your blind spots? Think about what really drives you crazy about other people. Perhaps you have similar challenges. Often what frustrates us most about other people is something we need to work on ourselves. Consciously observe others' reactions and subtle cues. Ask for feedback from people you trust. Listen. Consider. Reflect. Bring blind spots out into the light. Turn all of your blind spots into known weaknesses and then the known weaknesses into skills. Make it a quest to find out what everybody really thinks about you.

9. **Not sure of what you are good at? Find your hidden strengths.** You may have hidden strengths. Others see strengths that you don't know you have or don't think are stand-out skills. If you don't see them, you won't draw upon them. How do you find these strengths? First, through self-reflection. What comes easily to you? What do you enjoy? When does time fly by? In what settings or capacities do you get results? Think through situations, challenges, or interactions where you were at your best. What positive feedback have you received in the past? Like, "I always feel like you listen to what I am saying." Or, "Projects seem so easy when you are in the lead." When you hear something new, perk up your ears. Ask for clarification—seek to understand what the other person saw but you were unaware of. This can help you uncover some hidden strengths. Use feedback not only to learn what you're doing wrong, but what you're doing

right. Last, use self-reflection tools such as journaling to uncover hidden thoughts and ideas. After recording your experiences for a period of time, scan your journal. What themes do you see? What strengths are coming through?

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Baldoni, J. (2009, November 5). Use humility to improve performance. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Canaday, S. (2012, October 8). How to detect your blind spots that make your colleagues disrespect you. *Forbes*.

Smith, L. (2012, March). Larry Smith: Why you will fail to have a great career [Video file]. TED.

10. **Stuck in a personal awareness rut? Move to action.** Read a lot of self-help or personal development books? Like the content but have a hard time putting it into practice? Pore over your 360 results but aren't sure what to do with them? Caught off guard when given unanticipated feedback? Have trouble integrating it into your development strategy? It's easy to get stuck in a rut and fail to act. Reflection and information are valuable. But you can overdo self-reflection and get stuck in the process rather than taking action. Take stock of your strengths and development areas. Pick one or two and create a development plan. Focusing on fewer themes increases the likelihood that you can actually make a difference. Work with your boss, an HR representative, your coach to review your plan. Ask them to hold you accountable by checking in with you for progress.

11. **Don't have time to reflect? Build in a pause.** Life is busy. Urgent tasks get priority. Self-aware people build in time for what Kevin

Cashman calls *The Pause Principle*. “The conscious, intentional process of stepping back, within ourselves and outside of ourselves, to lead forward with greater authenticity, purpose, and contribution.” It looks different for different people. Meditation works for some. Others recognize they need daily physical activity. This becomes valuable reflection time for them. Daily walks. Journaling. The key is to take the time to reflect, however it makes sense to you. Consider. Appreciate. Debrief before moving forward or taking action. When you’ve completed a task or a project, hit the pause button. Rewind. Press play and review. What went well? What didn’t? What will you do differently next time? Ask others for their feedback. Reflect as a team. Allow the comments—yours and theirs—to settle before moving on. Self-aware people learn from experience and build it into their next activity.

12. Avoid admitting mistakes? Take ownership. Self-awareness is knowing when you are wrong and owning it. Admitting it not just to yourself, but to others. Made a mistake? Own up to it. Would have done something differently? Talk about it with others. Showing ownership to others helps them feel more comfortable giving you feedback and offering suggestions. Take the lead. Identify what you think went wrong. Talk first about what you would have done differently. Then ask others what they’d like to see you do differently in the future. Learn from experience. Reflect. Taking ownership shows openness to reflection and willingness to change.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Bregman, P. (2011, January 3). The best way to use the last five minutes of your day. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Jensen, K. (2012, July 3). Success is overrated: How do you handle your mistakes? *Forbes*.

Zwilling, M. (2012, May 26). *Don’t be too busy to do some reflective thinking*. Business Insider.

Job assignments

- Volunteer for an assignment in a different culture. Use this to become more aware of how you may respond in new or unfamiliar settings.
- Start something new. Begin something from scratch or build a new area of the organization. Build a new team.
- Take on an assignment that stretches your skills or pushes you to embrace a new challenge. Move to a new location, take on a position in a different area of the organization.
- Complete a 360. Consider who may be able to give you the best feedback, not just those who will tell you what you want to hear.
- Take on a new project outside your area of expertise. Make a point of asking those working with you for specific, honest, and regular feedback.

Take time to reflect...

If reflection doesn’t come naturally to you...

...then recognize that taking the time to look back and learn is an important part of moving forward. Think about what worked

and what didn't. Understand why. Modify your behavior to keep on the right track.

If you've ever been surprised by feedback you've received...

...then be aware that behaviors that feel natural to you may rub others the wrong way. Examine the disconnect between your intentions and others' perceptions. Work to close the gap.

If you're happy with how you are and don't want to change...

...then reflect before you reject. You might not recognize the feedback you receive or you may not like it, but don't discount it too early. Bite your tongue, take a deep breath, digest what you hear—then decide.

"Know yourself to improve yourself."

Auguste Comte – French philosopher



Learn more about **Demonstrates self-awareness**

Beh, E. (2012). *Powerful guidelines on effectively writing a personal development plan*. Self-Improvement Mentor. Retrieved from <http://www.self-improvement-mentor.com/writing-a-personal-development-plan.html>

Cashman, K. (2012). *The pause principle: Step back to lead forward*. San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers, Inc.

Kabat-Zinn, J. (2011). *Mindfulness for beginners: Reclaiming the present moment – and your life*. Boulder, CO: Sounds True, Inc.

London, M. (2003). *Job feedback: Giving, seeking, and using feedback for performance improvement*. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, Inc.

Rock, D. (2009). *Your brain at work: Strategies for overcoming distraction, regaining focus, and working smarter all day long*. New York, NY: HarperCollins Publishers.

Siegel, D. J. (2007). *The mindful brain: Reflection and attunement in the cultivation of well-being*. New York, NY: W. W. Norton & Company.

Van Hecke, M. L. (2007). *Blind spots: Why smart people do dumb things*. Amherst, NY: Prometheus Books.



Deep dive learning resource links

Ask a Manager. (2011, March 9). *How can I get critical feedback?* Askamanager.org. Retrieved from <http://www.askamanager.org/2011/03/how-can-i-get-critical-feedback.html>

Baldoni, J. (2009, November 5). Use humility to improve performance. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2009/11/use-humility-to-improve-perfor/>

Bregman, P. (2011, January 3). The best way to use the last five minutes of your day. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2011/01/the-best-way-to-use-the-last-f/>

Canaday, S. (2012, October 8). How to detect your blind spots that make your colleagues disrespect you. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://>

www.forbes.com/sites/forbesleadershipforum/2012/10/08/how-to-detect-your-blind-spots-that-make-your-colleagues-disrespect-you/

Donnelly, T. (2010, August 10). How to get feedback from employees. *Inc.* Retrieved from <http://www.inc.com/guides/2010/08/how-to-get-feedback-from-employees.html>

Gallo, A. (2012, May 15). How to get feedback when you're the boss. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2012/05/how-to-get-feedback-when-youre/>

Jensen, K. (2012, July 3). Success is overrated: How do you handle your mistakes? *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/keldjensen/2012/07/03/success-is-overrated-how-do-you-handle-your-mistakes/>

Robles, P. (2009, October 2). *How do you handle feedback?* Ecoconsultancy.com. Retrieved from <http://econsultancy.com/blog/4705-how-do-you-handle-feedback>

Smith, J. (2013, January 29). How negative feedback can help your career. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/jacquelynsmith/2013/01/29/how-negative-feedback-can-help-your-career/>

Smith, L. (2012, March). Larry Smith: Why you will fail to have a great career [Video file]. TED. Retrieved from http://www.ted.com/talks/larry_smith_why_you_will_fail_to_have_a_great_career.html

Wright, K. (2011, March 15). How to take feedback. *Psychology Today*. Retrieved from <http://www.psychologytoday.com/articles/201103/how-take-feedback>

Zwilling, M. (2012, May 26). *Don't be too busy to do some reflective thinking*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://>

www.businessinsider.com/dont-be-too-busy-to-do-some-reflective-thinking-2012-6

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore *Demonstrates* self-awareness further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Dealing with feedback.
- Finding your blind spots.
- How to gather feedback from colleagues.
- How to learn from feedback.
- Learning your hidden strengths.
- Personal development tips.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



30. SELF-DEVELOPMENT

Actively seeking new ways to grow and be challenged using both formal and informal development channels.

The bottom line is, those who learn, grow, and change continuously across their careers are the most successful. The skills someone has now are unlikely to be enough in the future. Acquiring new skills is the best way to navigate an uncertain future. Some won't face their limitations. They make excuses. Blame it on the boss or the job or the organization. Others are defensive and fight any corrective feedback. Some are reluctant to do anything about their problems. Some want a quick fix—they don't have time for development. Other times, people simply don't know what to do. There is great value in learning to learn from experience. Becoming a lifelong learner isn't just a catchphrase. Being committed to self-development means you look for ways to build skills that you will need in the future. You look to grow from experience. Seek out feedback and are open to what you hear. Challenge yourself in unfamiliar settings. Try out new skills. Learn from others. Outcome? Work is more interesting. You are less likely to get stuck in a rut—or in your current position. You can stretch yourself to develop and grow in ways that perhaps you didn't think you could. Development is a personal commitment. You make the choice.



*"Celebrate what you've accomplished,
but raise the bar a little higher each time you succeed."*

Mia Hamm – American soccer player

Self-development is in the **Self** factor (IV) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster K, **Being open**, along with *Demonstrates self-awareness* (29). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in that chapter to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Shows personal commitment and takes action to continuously improve.**
- ★ **Accepts assignments that broaden capabilities.**
- ★ **Learns from new experiences, from others, and from structured learning.**
- ★ **Makes the most of available development resources.**

Less skilled

- Doesn't put in the effort to grow and change.
- Is comfortable with current skills.
- Is fearful of making mistakes that accompany development.
- Lacks awareness or interest in using available developmental resources.

Talented

- Takes consistent action to develop new skills.
- Finds ways to apply strengths to new issues.
- Is aware of the skills needed to be successful in different situations and levels.
- Seeks assignments that stretch him/her beyond comfort zone.

Overused skill

- Develops just for the sake of development, without focus or objective.
- Focuses on own development at the expense of meeting other obligations.
- May be susceptible to the latest self-help fads.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Self-development. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Arrogant; doesn't have any weaknesses.
- Defensive.

- Doesn't know what to develop.
- Doesn't know what to do.
- Doesn't think people really can change.
- Fears failure or admitting shortcomings.
- Too busy getting work done.
- Afraid of new experiences.
- Unsure of what is needed at the next level.
- Relies on the organization for development.
- Satisfied with current skills.



Brain booster

Everything we do demands some level of energy and attention. The newer the task, the more challenging the task, the more brain fuel is required. When your brain is busy putting forth tremendous effort on one activity, there is less capacity for other things. And you become depleted and need to recharge. Improving your skill diminishes the energy required to do a particular task. Make an up-front investment to hone a skill, then once you've mastered something, take the most economical approach to it. This frees up your brain to pay attention to more things at once. Take on more complex problems. Learn new skills.

Tips to develop Self-development

1. **See yourself as not being able to develop? Change your mindset.** Some people are natural learners. They always look to learn something new from every situation. Some people are not natural learners. They are more performance oriented—get the

job done and move on. Performance-oriented people tend to avoid new situations in which they may fail. Why? Because failing at a task translates to judgment, in their mind. Natural learners are more willing to take the risk because they are less worried about how they may be perceived by others. To them, the learning is the outcome. It is less about confidence in their ability and more about growing. Did you know you can shift your mindset? You can train yourself to be a learner. But you must be willing to expand your horizon. Be curious. Continuously look for opportunities to stretch yourself. See each situation as a learning opportunity.

2. **Not sure where to start? Do a skills audit.** First, get a good multi-source assessment, a 360 questionnaire, or poll 10 people who know you well to give you detailed feedback. What are you doing well? Not so well? What should you keep doing? Stop doing? You don't want to waste time on developing things that turn out not to be needs. At the same time, rate yourself. What do you see as your strengths? What areas do you need to develop? Where do you suspect you have strengths but you haven't had the opportunity to try? Group your skills into categories. Clear strengths—me at my best. Overdone strengths—I do too much of a good thing. So much so that it is limiting my success. Hidden strengths—others rate me higher than I rate myself. These are untapped resources. Blind spots—I rate myself higher than others rate me. These are behaviors that get in the way of your success without your awareness. Weaknesses—I don't do it well. Obvious areas that you know you need to improve upon. Untested areas—I've never been involved in that area. Don't knows—I need more feedback. Once you have your skills grouped into categories, create a plan of attack. What is most

important for you to work on now? Where can you have the biggest impact now and for the future? Figure out a plan for how to grow in this area.

3. **Wondering what to focus on? Identify your values and organizational priorities.** Feedback is helpful, but you need to place it in context to determine priorities. First, ask yourself a few questions. What matters to you? What motivates you? What is most interesting to you? What do you want to accomplish in your career? What is important for success in your current role? What would help you be more successful here? Leveraging strengths? Overcoming certain weaknesses? Also consider your future. Where do you want to go? What are the skills that are needed in your next position? When you compare your current capabilities with where you want to go, you can identify areas for development that are most essential. Second, identify what matters to others. What do other people—such as your boss, senior management, and others—expect from you and desire from you? What is important to the organization? Identify the sweet spot between what is important to you, important to the organization, and where there are gaps between these values and your skill set. These are your developmental priorities.
4. **Want to be ready for your next role? Do your research and be prepared.** Think about what you want to accomplish next in your career. A lateral move? International assignment? More leadership responsibility? Moving to a new functional area? Think through what skills are necessary to be successful in this role. Do your research. Work with HR or ask someone who's currently in the job. What skills do people have who are successful in this role? Then,

compare. How do your strengths align with this new role? Where do you need further development? Where are the gaps? Start working toward closing those gaps. When the opportunity arises, you want to be ready to move.

5. **Know what you need to develop? Prioritize.** Once you have compared your skill set to what is important for success now and in your next role, identify your development priorities. But not too many! People are most successful when they work on one or two things at a time. Set your development goals. Make a plan. Share your plan with someone else. You are more likely to achieve success if you have built in accountability measures. Ask for their help. Make sure that your goals are SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound) goals. Start small and work up as you experience success.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Goodman, N. (2012, September 18). 4 Ways to discover your strengths. *Entrepreneur*.

Guey, L. (2013, May 24). *Instant MBA: Most people don't know themselves as well as they think*. Business Insider.

Olson, L. (2011, January 27). How to set yourself up for promotion. *U.S. News & World Report*.

Scivicque, C. (2011, June 21). Creating your professional development plan: 3 Surprising truths. *Forbes*.

6. **Not applying your talents? Leverage your strengths.** A Gallup study found that individuals who are coached to utilize their strengths are more engaged employees in terms of productivity

and tenure. Part of self-development is knowing when to draw upon the strengths you already possess. Where do you have skills that aren't being utilized? What have you mastered? What do you learn quickly? What gives you the most satisfaction at work? What are three things you can start doing today? Where can you use your strengths to help others? Can't use your strengths in your current job? How about a project, special assignment, or a task trade? Maintain the clear strengths you will need in the future by testing them in new task assignments. Coach others on your strengths. In turn, ask others to coach you on theirs.

7. **Never tried it? Focus on untested areas.** Minimize weaknesses, but also go after untested areas—skills that you have not developed but are likely to be important in the future. Often, people are promoted based on their performance in their current job. But the skills needed in their next position may be very different. In our research, we find that managers are rated as "highly skilled" on behaviors that are more tied to performance at the individual contributor level. Not enough development is happening over time. Few managers are good at developing talent at first. Few executives are good at driving vision and purpose. But did they ever have a real chance to develop in these areas? The key is to find out the core demands of performance in a role, then develop the skills before they are necessary. Get involved in small versions of your untested areas. Write a strategic plan for your unit, then show it to people. Negotiate the purchase of office furniture. Onboard someone new. Write down what you did well and what you didn't do well. Then try a second, bigger task. Again, assess the experience. At this point, you may want to

read a book or attend a course in this area. Keep upping the size and stakes until you have the skill at the level you need it to be.

8. Signing up for class after class? Learn on the job. Learning does not only happen in a classroom or through a book. The best learning happens when you are on the job. Use real-life challenges as learning experiences. Volunteer for a special project. Help a person learn something within your expertise. Take on a project. Volunteer to sit on a task force. Task forces are an effective way to learn from your peers and expand your business knowledge. They require learning other functions and businesses. Work with different cultures or nationalities. Work with others in a collaborative manner to rapidly address an issue. Diversity of experience is the single best way to develop new skills. Try something new every day to force yourself outside of your comfort zone. These opportunities stretch your skills in a real-life way. They push you to work with different people. They broaden your horizon. Venture beyond your normal experience and look at things from a different light.

9. Not leveraging development resources available to you? Find a coach or a mentor. Pick a person in the organization who is known for their strength in the area that you'd like to develop. Observe what they do and how they do it. If possible, ask for a meeting/lunch to discuss their success and the things they have learned. See if the person has any interest in teaching you something and being a temporary coach. Get to know other potential advocates on- and off-work. Go for maximum variety in the towering strengths they possess. Working with a mentor is a great way to develop. But, vary your mentors and coaches. Try

not to get stuck in a rut relying on the same people for much of your career. You don't want to become a "mini me" of your mentor. Utilize a variety of people to help you develop the skills you are looking to grow.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Burns, K. (2010, January 13). 13 Tips on finding a mentor. *U.S. News & World Report*.

Garnett, L. (2013, August 16). How to leverage your true talent. *Inc.*

Herbert, W. (2012, July 2). *Learning on the job: Myth vs science*. Association for Psychological Science.

Zenger, J. (2013, July 16). Throw your old plan away: 6 New ways to build leadership development into your job. *Forbes*.

10. Don't learn from experience? Become reflective. People who are good at self-development build time into their schedule to develop from experiences. They seek to achieve results but also look to learn and grow from a situation. After each experience—whether a project, task force, new challenge—reflect. What went well? What didn't? What could you have done differently to achieve a better outcome? What skills were you lacking? Where do you need additional expertise or experience? Take your learning and put it into practice the next time. Add the learning to your development plan. How can you continue to build on it? Use your experience to help drive your future growth. Watch out for the "haven't the time" trap. There's always something that seems more important than reflection. But check yourself. Don't rush to the next task. Plan to reflect.

11. Need support? Show others you take your development seriously. State your development needs and ask for their help. Research shows that people are much more likely to help and give the benefit of the doubt to those who admit their shortcomings and try to do something about them. They know it takes courage. Don't stop at asking for feedback. Ask people for their help in your development. Can they act as a coach? Can they teach you a new skill? Can they be a springboard for new ideas? Utilize the people around you to help in your development.

12. Frustrated by lack of progress? Understand that development takes time. Development doesn't happen overnight. It takes time to make changes that are noticeable, sustainable, and position you well for future success. Just like there is no "easy" button to prepare for a marathon, plan a significant event, or write a book, there are no shortcuts for your own growth. Research suggests that deliberate and sustained practice is necessary to really hone a skill to make it a strength. Malcolm Gladwell, in *Outliers: The Story of Success*, reports that people need to practice something for 10,000 hours before they master the skill. It can be a long haul. Set your goals. Work your plan. Celebrate small wins along the way.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Capture Your Flag. (2013, June 14). Learning to reflect more and get to know yourself better [YouTube].

Petriglieri, G. (2013, February 6). Getting stuck can help you grow. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Tjan, A. K. (2012, July 19). How leaders become self-aware. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Zenger, J. (2013, August 29). Personal development isn't personal: 3 Tips for getting your manager involved. *Forbes*.

Job assignments

- Take on a task that you have never tried, dislike or hate to do, and is outside of your domain. Stick to it and focus on the learning you're deriving from it.
- Teach/coach someone how to do something you're an expert in. Invite them to tap into your knowledge and the lessons you took from your experiences.
- Attend a course or event which will push you personally beyond your usual limits or outside your comfort zone.
- Find and spend time with an expert to learn something in an area new to you, in either a work or non-work setting.
- Take on an assignment outside of your current organizational area or region to practice working within a different organizational or global culture.

Take time to reflect...

If you think development is always a formal affair...

...then consider that you've probably been learning through new challenges you take on. Accelerate the process by being conscious of it. Consider how you want to grow. Make a plan. Take action every day.

If you know you have skill gaps and are uncomfortable with that...

...then accept that fallibility is not failure. There's no disgrace in being less than perfect. Most flaws can be fixed. Design your development plan to fill the most important gaps.

If you can't seem to find time to learn anything new...

...then recognize that developing yourself doesn't have to be a separate event. Take just a few minutes a day to try something you've never tried before or do something in a different way. Practice a new skill each week.

"The only difference between a rut and a grave are the dimensions."

Ellen Glasgow – American author



Learn more about Self-development

Beh, E. (2012). *Powerful guidelines on effectively writing a personal development plan*. Self-Improvement Mentor. Retrieved from <http://www.self-improvement-mentor.com/writing-a-personal-development-plan.html>

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Throop, R. K., & Castellucci, M. B. (2011). *Reaching your potential: Personal and professional development*. Boston, MA: Cengage Learning.



Deep dive learning resource links

Burns, K. (2010, January 13). 13 Tips on finding a mentor. *U.S. News & World Report*. Retrieved from <http://money.usnews.com/money/blogs/outside-voices-careers/2010/01/13/13-tips-on-finding-a-mentor>

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Goodman, N. (2012, September 18). 4 Ways to discover your strengths. *Entrepreneur*. Retrieved from <http://www.entrepreneur.com/blog/224433>

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[development-isnt-personal-3-tips-for-getting-your-manager-involved/](http://www.forbes.com/sites/jackzenger/2013/08/29/personal-development-isnt-personal-3-tips-for-getting-your-manager-involved/)

Zenger, J. (2013, July 16). Throw your old plan away: 6 New ways to build leadership development into your job. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/jackzenger/2013/07/16/throw-your-old-plan-away-6-new-ways-to-build-leadership-development-into-your-job/>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Self-development further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Creating a personal development plan.
- Developing in your role.
- How to leverage your own talent.
- Looking for a mentor.
- Patience with personal development.
- Personal SWOT analysis.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



31. SITUATIONAL ADAPTABILITY

Adapting approach and demeanor in real time to match the shifting demands of different situations.

Those skilled at situational adaptability recognize the need to be flexible and act differently because no two situations are exactly alike. They know that using the same approach, tone, and style in different settings may be consistent but not necessarily effective. You wouldn't behave the same way in a team brainstorming discussion as you would when managing a customer complaint or navigating a politically charged strategy session. Quickly adjusting and fine-tuning your behavior in real time allows you to be versatile in different situations and interactions with others. Situational adaptability means paying attention to circumstances and adjusting accordingly. Bringing empathy in times of stress and change, firm direction in times of uncertainty, or diplomacy in times of conflict. Continuously gauge the impact you're having and stay alert to make adjustments to your demeanor and approach. Be flexible to meet the needs of the moment. The outcome will be ease of transaction and effectiveness of interaction.



*"A wise man adapts himself to circumstances,
as water shapes itself to the vessel that contains it."*

– Chinese proverb

Situational adaptability is in the **Self** factor (IV) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster L, **Being flexible and adaptable**, along with *Manages ambiguity* (3), *Nimble learning* (22), and *Being resilient* (26). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Picks up on situational cues and adjusts in the moment.**
- ★ **Readily adapts personal, interpersonal, and leadership behavior.**
- ★ **Understands that different situations may call for different approaches.**
- ★ **Can act differently depending on the circumstances.**

Less skilled

- Uses same style and approach regardless of the situation.
- Fails to notice changing situational demands.
- Expects others to adjust to his/her preferred style and approach.
- Thinks being true to self is all that matters.
- Doesn't take time to understand interpersonal dynamics.

Talented

- Picks up on the need to change personal, interpersonal, and leadership behavior quickly.
- Observes situational and group dynamics and selects best-fit approach.
- Seamlessly adapts style to fit the specific needs of others.

Overused skill

- May be seen as a social chameleon, leaving others unsure of when he/she is being genuine.
- Is hypervigilant in monitoring situational dynamics to the point that the desired outcome isn't met; may come across as indecisive or wavering.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Situational adaptability. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Sticks to a single preferred style.
- Oblivious to interpersonal dynamics.
- Focused only on own agenda.
- Subscribes to "I am what I am."
- Defensive in the face of criticism.
- Doesn't read others well.
- Poor communication skills.
- Rigid in values and beliefs.



Does it best

Rock star, business partner, philanthropist, and political activist. U2's Irish-born Bono wears many hats. Whether he's on tour or at a charity event, he is arresting and dynamic. As a business partner, he is shrewd and solution oriented. As a philanthropist, he is empathetic and creative—seeking ways to raise money to fight poverty and disease. As a political activist, Bono is respectful and focused on dialogue when he meets with world leaders to discuss debt relief and other humanitarian efforts. And, while he didn't begin his career with the ability to play all of these roles, he has gradually grown comfortable in a variety of situations: guest editing an issue of *Vanity Fair*, launching (PRODUCT)RED™ with iconic global brands, collaborating with a diverse list of artists and writers, and graciously receiving countless awards for his music as well as his humanitarian work.

Tips to develop Situational adaptability

1. **Find it hard to read others? Tune in.** Everyone is different. Some differences are easy to see. Height. Weight. Speed. Others are a little harder to gauge. Motivated; not so motivated. Engaged; disengaged. Confident; anxious. To really understand what's going on with people in a given situation, you need to tune in to what's going on beneath the surface. Pay close attention to what people say or do first. What do they emphasize in their behavior or speech? People focus on different things—taking action, details, concepts, feelings, other people. What's their interaction style? Pushy, tough, soft, matter-of-fact, and so on. Listen for values, for the things that ignite passion and emotion. Don't fight their style; accept their preferred mode of doing things. Take

control of the situation by adapting your style and behavior and by responding in a way that eases the transaction and promotes a productive outcome.

- 2. Not sure what approach to take? Think about the consequences.** Use mental rehearsal to think about different ways you could engage. Picture the response. Try to see yourself acting in opposing ways to get to the same outcome—being tough, letting others decide, deflecting the issue. What cues would you look for to select an approach that matches what you want to accomplish? Imagine trying to get the same thing done with two different groups with two different approaches. How do they play out in your mind? Now focus on the situation at hand and the players involved—which approach will likely yield the best outcome?
- 3. Struggle to control your instant reaction? Press pause.** You may have been told that you need to practice self-control. That you respond to situations as if they were threats instead of the way life is. That you're too quick to react. When your emotions and fears are triggered, it can cause an initial anxious response. It usually lasts around 40–60 seconds. You need to buy some time before you say or do something inappropriate. Practice holding back your first response long enough to think of a second and third. Research shows that, generally, somewhere between the second and third thing you think to say or do is the best option. Rather than reacting, adapt and thoughtfully respond to the situation instead. Stay in control. Focus on the impression you want to make, given the situation. Manage your shifts, don't be a prisoner of them.

- 4. Make snap judgments about what's going on? Listen more.** Listening helps you get a read on what's going on with others. When you listen, you're suspending judgment. You're taking in information that will allow you to select the best response to the situation. You're pausing to see what you might be missing. Don't interrupt and don't instantly judge. Speak briefly and summarize often. Give reasons for everything you're saying. When you disagree, do so in a way that invites others to respond. For example, "I don't think so, but what do you think?" Restate what others have said to signal understanding. Nod. Jot down notes. Elicit and listen to as much information as you can about what's going on. Use that information to adapt your behavior as needed.
- 5. In a hurry to get down to business? Manage the first three minutes.** Managing the first three minutes of any situation is essential. The tone is set. First impressions are formed. Work on being open and approachable. On taking in information during the beginning of a transaction. This means putting others at ease so that they feel OK about disclosing. It means initiating rapport, listening, sharing, understanding, and comforting. Approachable people get more information, know things earlier, and can get others to do more things. The more you can get others to speak up early in the transaction, the more you'll know about where they're coming from and the better you can tailor your approach.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Bhasin, K., & Nisen, M. (2013, March 27). *26 Tips on how to read people*. Business Insider.

Biro, M. M. (2013, August 4). 5 Leadership lessons: Listen, learn, lead. *Forbes*.

Goudreau, J. (2013, January 9). From crying to temper tantrums: How to manage emotions at work. *Forbes*.

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *The Hersey-Blanchard Situational Leadership® Theory*. Mind Tools.

- 6. Need exposure to different ways of behaving? Go for more variety.** Repeatedly taking on the same assignments, dealing with the same situations, or continually playing the same role prevents you from expanding your repertoire. Get out of your comfort zone. Put yourself into very different situations than those you typically encounter. Volunteer for assignments that represent a new challenge. Push yourself forward to play different situational roles. From facilitator to director. From harmonizer to orchestrator of productive conflict. From leader to follower. Operating in a variety of situations and roles will help you become more flexible and adaptable. Research shows that people with a broad behavioral repertoire and the ability to perform roles that include contradictions will be the most effective.
- 7. Trouble shifting gears? Practice the transitions.** As one song says, "I've gotta be me." Not many of us have that luxury all the time. Each situation we deal with is a little bit, somewhat, or a lot different. To be effective, you need to read the situation and the people, then behave appropriately. Be in control at 9 a.m., a

follower at 10 a.m., quiet at 11 a.m., and dominating at noon. Respectful with the boss, critiquing with peers, caring for direct reports, and responding to customers. Go from confronting people to being approachable. From firing someone to a business-as-usual staff meeting. It's all in a day's work. Monitor your gear-shifting behavior for a week at work and at home. Between activities, if only for a few seconds, think about the transition you're making and the frame of mind needed to make it work well. Which do you find easy? Why? Which do you find toughest? List the five transitions you find most difficult. Write down how each one makes you feel and what stops you from being effective. Create a plan that focuses on developing the skills and behaviors required to skillfully execute what needs to be done.

- 8. Ready to learn from others? Study transition experts.** Interview people who are good at shifting gears, such as fix-it managers (tear down and build back up), shutdown managers (fire people yet support them and help them find other employment, and motivate those who stay), or excellent parents. Talk to an actor or actress to see how they can play opposing roles back-to-back. Talk to people who have recently joined your organization from places quite different than yours. Talk to a therapist who hears a different problem or trauma every hour. See if you can figure out some rules for making comfortable transitions.
- 9. Unsure of your impact in certain situations? Get feedback.** People can be reluctant to give you feedback, especially negative or corrective information. Generally, to get it, you must ask for it. The best time to ask for it is while the situation is happening or

immediately after. If people are reluctant to give criticism, help by making self-appraisal statements—"I think I talked too long on that topic in the meeting, what do you think?" Do some self-reflection too. How did you think, feel, and behave in the situation? Did you achieve the right outcome? How did others react to you? Use the feedback you get from others, and yourself, to determine what you'd do differently next time. Research shows that people who reflect on their performance are more likely to be flexible in adapting to changes in their environment. And therefore better able to identify alternative ways of behaving to be more effective in given situations.

10. Afraid to make a mistake? Laugh at yourself. Having a sense of humor about yourself only serves to humanize you. Funny stories about situations where you were embarrassed, did the wrong thing, fumbled a well-rehearsed line, or committed a faux pas are opportunities to learn while entertaining yourself and others. When you fail, reflect on what went wrong, adjust course, and don't repeat the same mistake next time. Learning and improving your adaptability along the way is the goal, not perfection.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Allworth, J. (2012, March 22). How to get into your zone. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Dehne, S. (2009, March 27). *5 Tips for facing change at work*. Career Builder.

Huffington Post. (2013, November 14). Why it's incredibly important to learn to laugh at yourself. *The Huffington Post*.

Warrell, M. (2013, April 22). Why getting comfortable with discomfort is crucial to success. *Forbes*.

11. Too much of a good thing? Pull back on overused skills. Tend to overdo things, especially things you're good at? Lots of people overuse their strengths. Push for results too hard. Analyze data too long. Try to be too nice. For those overdone behaviors, it's hard to do the opposite. Get feedback to find out what you overdo. Either through a 360 feedback instrument or by polling your closest associates. Find out how adaptable people think you are under pressure and how well you handle the fragmentation of a typical day. Work on balancing your behavior. If you get brusque under pressure, take three deep breaths and consciously slow down or use some humor. If you're too tough, ask yourself how you'd like to be treated in this situation. If you run over others, tell them what you're thinking about doing and ask them what they think should be done. If you habitually go into an action frenzy or grind to a halt, ask yourself what would be more effective right now. Strengths become overused skills when you use them, regardless of the situation. Be more precise and adjust to the specific need.

- 12. Trouble finding balance? Combine seemingly opposite behaviors.** Many situations call for mixed responses and behaviors. Kaiser and Overfield (2010) labeled this type of approach the “mastery of opposites”—combining opposing but complementary behaviors. Delivering a tough message on layoffs but doing it in a compassionate way. Taking strong stands but listening and leaving room for others to maneuver. Having a strong personal belief about an issue but loyally implementing an organization plan which opposes your view. Being playful but firm. Being loose with parts of the budget but unyielding in others. Doing two opposing things at once isn’t comfortable for everyone. Many pride themselves on being just one person, believing and following one set of beliefs. Situational adaptability doesn’t really violate that. It just means within your normal range of behaviors and style, you use two of your extremes—being as quiet as you can be in the first half of the meeting and as loud as you ever are in the second half.
- 13. Selling someone else’s vision? Get comfortable walking someone else’s talk.** Having to support someone else’s program or idea when you don’t really think that way or agree is a common paradox. You have to be a member of the loyal opposition. Most of the time, you may be delivering someone else’s view of the future. Top management and a consultant created the mission, vision, and strategy off somewhere in the woods. You may or may not have been asked for any input. You may even have some doubts about it yourself. Don’t offer conditional statements to your audience. Don’t let it be known to others that you are not fully on board. Your role is to manage this vision and mission, not

your personal one. If you have strong contrary views, be sure to demand a voice next time around.

- 14. Adjusting too much or too little? Redress the balance.** Focus too much on pleasing and accommodating others and not enough on being you? You could be at risk of adjusting too much, too often. People may perceive that you’re inconsistent and waffling or, even worse, manipulative and inauthentic. If you’re making wild swings in personality between different interactions and situations, stop. Take steps to redress the balance. Pay as much attention to your own needs and values as you do those of others. Focus on being authentic while being sensitive to the needs of the situation. Maybe you’re the opposite? Maybe you don’t adjust your approach for fear of not presenting your “true self” or projecting a “false image.” If you neglect to adjust, you risk being seen as someone who tramples over others, is overly rigid, or dogmatic. Remember, adjusting your approach isn’t about being disingenuous or inauthentic. It’s about introducing the right approach and behavior at the right time to get the right result. Don’t stick rigidly to one way of operating. Pay attention to what the situation requires of you and adjust accordingly.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Lie, E. (2010, November 18). *Instant MBA: Striking the right balance between rigid and flexible management will motivate employees*. Business Insider.

Martinuzzi, B. (n.d.). *The agile leader: Adaptability*. Mind Tools.

Vlachoutsicos, C. (2012, December 7). What being an “authentic leader” really means. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Warrell, M. (2013, May 20). Why leaders must “get real” – 5 ways to unlock authentic leadership. *Forbes*.

Job assignments

- Set tasks that force you to shift gears, such as being a spokesperson in a tough issue, making peace with an enemy, or managing a team of novices. Try new behaviors and seek feedback on your approach.
- Support the implementation of a controversial new project or process that wasn't your idea and that you don't fully agree with. Mentally rehearse how you will respond to challenges from your audience.
- Take on a tough project where there are no clear answers or paths to completion. Wear different hats as you figure out how to deal with the variety of situations.
- Help people infuse humor into their presentations. Adept use of humor requires a good understanding of the situation, the audience, what will play, what would go over their heads and what would fall flat.

- Volunteer to teach others something you don't know how to do the next time a new procedure, policy, or technology appears. This will force you to shift from experienced expert to novice.

Take time to reflect...

If you rely on one or two ways of handling most situations...

...then think of behaviors as tools. You don't need a sledge hammer to crack a walnut. A spoon won't help when you need a shovel. Use what's best to get the job done.

If you feel self-conscious when trying out different ways...

...then recognize that adaptability is like a muscle. It gets stronger with exercise. Relax. Have fun with it. Today's awkward straining can be tomorrow's natural flexing.

If you feel changing too much means you're not being yourself...

...then understand that if situations shift, staying the same isn't always an option. When the old route is blocked, you need a new map to guide you to the new route.

“When you are frustrated and do not know a way out, only flexibility and moderation toward difficulties will save you.”

Husayn ibn Ali – Early Muslim Imam



Learn more about Situational adaptability

George, B., & Sims, P. (2007). *True north: Discover your authentic leadership*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.

- Gurvis, J., & Calarco, A. (2007). *Adaptability: Responding effectively to change*. Greensboro, NC: Center for Creative Leadership.
- Hamel, G. (2012). *What matters now: How to win in a world of relentless change, ferocious competition, and unstoppable innovation*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.
- Heath, C., & Heath, D. (2010). *Switch: How to change things when change is hard*. New York, NY: Broadway Books.
- Kaiser, R. B., & Overfield, D. V. (2010). Assessing flexible leadership as a mastery of opposites. *Consulting Psychology Journal: Practice and Research*, 62(2), 105-118.



Deep dive learning resource links

- Allworth, J. (2012, March 22). How to get into your zone. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2012/03/how-to-get-into-your-zone/>
- Bhasin, K., & Nisen, M. (2013, March 27). *26 Tips on how to read people*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://www.businessinsider.com/how-to-read-other-people-2013-3>
- Biro, M. M. (2013, August 4). 5 Leadership lessons: Listen, learn, lead. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/meghanbiro/2013/08/04/5-leadership-lessons-listen-learn-lead/>
- Dehne, S. (2009, March 27). *5 Tips for facing change at work*. Career Builder. Retrieved from <http://www.careerbuilder.com/Article/CB-1192-The-Workplace-5-Tips-for-Facing-Change-at-Work/>
- Goudreau, J. (2013, January 9). From crying to temper tantrums: How to manage emotions at work. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/jennagoudreau/2013/01/09/from-crying-to-temper-tantrums-how-to-manage-emotions-at-work/>
- Huffington Post. (2013, November 14). Why it's incredibly important to learn to laugh at yourself. *The Huffington Post*. Retrieved from http://www.huffingtonpost.com/2013/11/14/10-successful-people-who-_n_4262766.html
- Lie, E. (2010, November 18). *Instant MBA: Striking the right balance between rigid and flexible management will motivate employees*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://www.businessinsider.com/instant-mba-hit-the-right-balance-between-rigid-and-flexible-2010-11>
- Martinuzzi, B. (n.d.). *The agile leader: Adaptability*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newLDR_49.htm
- Mind Tools. (n.d.). *The Hersey-Blanchard Situational Leadership® Theory*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newLDR_44.htm
- Vlachoutsicos, C. (2012, December 7). What being an “authentic leader” really means. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2012/12/what-being-an-authentic-leader-really-means/>
- Warrell, M. (2013, April 22). Why getting comfortable with discomfort is crucial to success. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/margiewarrell/2013/04/22/is-comfort-holding-you-back/>
- Warrell, M. (2013, May 20). Why leaders must “get real” – 5 ways to unlock authentic leadership. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://>

www.forbes.com/sites/margiewarrell/2013/05/20/why-leaders-must-get-real/

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Situational adaptability further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Embracing change in the workplace.
- Flexible leadership.
- Knowing when to change your approach.
- Learning to read others.
- Managing your emotions in the workplace.
- Situational leadership.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



32. BALANCES STAKEHOLDERS

Anticipating and balancing the needs of multiple stakeholders.

A stakeholder has a legitimate claim, or a “stake.” Stakeholders affect or are affected by the actions of an individual or the organization. They may be internal to the organization or external. Decision makers or decision approvers. Information providers or information seekers. They may be actively involved or on the sidelines. They may have different priorities—sometimes complementary, sometimes conflicting. That’s what makes balancing stakeholder needs so important. Getting anything of value done today isn’t a go-it-alone proposition. Stakeholders are critical to the success of any strategy, initiative, or project. They may be the team in charge of executing your vision. Or the person who pulls the approval strings. They could be the customer. Investors. The board. Stakeholders can be advocates for you or just as easily be blockers. Creating the right balance in working with stakeholders can mean the difference between a project flying or crashing. And it’s a juggling act. Knowing who to engage with and when. Who to inform and to what degree. Who has something you need to be successful and what they expect in return. And recognizing that balancing often means you won’t please every stakeholder every time.



“Find the appropriate balance of competing claims by various groups of stakeholders. All claims deserve consideration but some claims are more important than others.”

Warren G. Bennis – American scholar, organizational consultant, and author

Balances stakeholders is in the **Thought** factor (I) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster B, **Making complex decisions**, along with *Manages complexity* (8) and *Decision quality* (12). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Understands internal and external stakeholder requirements, expectations, and needs.**
- ★ **Balances the interests of multiple stakeholders.**
- ★ **Considers cultural and ethical factors in the decision-making process.**
- ★ **Acts fairly despite conflicting demands of stakeholders.**

Less skilled

- Focuses on meeting current expectations and needs of a limited number of stakeholders.
- Considers some stakeholders' interests more strongly than others'.
- Allows conflicting stakeholder demands to unfairly influence actions.

Talented

- Maintains frequent interactions with a broad stakeholder network.
- Takes a proactive approach to shape and influence stakeholder expectations.
- Serves as a liaison between different stakeholder groups.
- Effectively aligns the interests of multiple, diverse stakeholders.

Overused skill

- Spends too much time interacting with stakeholders, slowing down decision making.
- Is too focused on clarifying stakeholder needs and building consensus among stakeholders when others are looking for clear direction on day-to-day business matters.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with *Balances* stakeholders. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Poor communication skills.
- Wants to please everyone.
- Poor influencer.

- Ineffective networker.
- Not attuned to others' needs.
- Weak at building relationships.
- Not strategic.
- Avoids conflict.
- Narrow perspective.
- Uncomfortable with complexity.



Does it best

With around 44,000 service stations and 10 million customers to satisfy every day, balancing stakeholders is a tall order for Shell's leaders. They recognize five areas of stakeholder responsibility: shareholders, customers, employees, suppliers, and society. All have different priorities and all are essential to Shell's success. Shareholders want their investment protected. Employees need to be safe, healthy, and motivated. Suppliers need good business relationships with Shell. Customers want value for their money as well as cleaner, more efficient fuels. Communities need to be reassured of a safe environment. To ensure the needs of all its stakeholder groups are met, Shell applies three criteria in its decision making: the economic impact, the social impact, and the long-term effect. Shell leaders make it their business to understand what's important to people and go the extra mile to act upon it. For example, Shell LiveWire is an online community for young entrepreneurs. Shell provides resources and information to help them turn their ideas into reality. With annual revenue in excess of US\$480 billion, Shell was number one in

Fortune's Global 500 in 2013. Shell's efforts to balance stakeholder relationships have led to significant competitive advantage.

Tips to develop *Balances* stakeholders

1. Don't know where to start? Identify your stakeholders.

Balancing stakeholders effectively starts with knowing who they are. And often your stakeholder group will extend further than you think. Start by considering everyone who could be impacted by what you're working on. Better to start big and narrow it down than overlook people. Who is impacted by the change your strategy or project will bring? Who will support it? Who will fight it? Who has influence and power over what you're doing? Who has an interest in whether the project succeeds or fails? Who has something to contribute—information, time, resources? Get others to help you identify stakeholders. Involve your sponsor, a trusted advisor, or someone in the know. Who do they see as your stakeholders? Scan internally and consider the less obvious functions. Look outside the organization to groups who may also have a stake. Customers. Suppliers. Community groups. Governmental agencies. Analysts. Make your list, then critique it. Who have you missed? Who's on it that shouldn't be? Leave it. Go back to it. Update it. Keep at it until you're satisfied.

2. Not sure who you're dealing with? Get to know your stakeholders. It's one thing to determine who your stakeholders are, but how much do you actually know about them? To manage them and balance their needs, you have to know what makes them tick. Analyze your stakeholder group. Get to know them. Understand them. Complete a stakeholder analysis to structure your thinking and ensure you cover everything. Here's a start:

- What's their connection to the project?
- What financial interests do they have?
- What motivates them?
- What's their current view of the situation?
- How are they likely to feel about the intended outcome of what you're working on?
- Who else might influence their opinions?
- What information do you want from them?
- What's strategically important to them?
- What's their vision for their part of the organization?
- Where is their thinking in terms of changes taking place in the organization?
- What history do they have that could be significant to the future?

Test yourself. If you can't answer the questions, then do some research. Ask people who know them. Ask the stakeholders themselves. Look into their background and experience. Think about how your work links to their role. Build a clear picture that will form the foundation of your interaction with them.

3. Stuck at the starting gate? Engage key stakeholders early.

Getting an idea off the ground can be a tricky business. Sometimes you need all the help you can get to start things moving. So make use of some of your most powerful stakeholders. Those who know the organization well. Those who can influence decisions. Get them on board right from the beginning by asking them to help you define and shape the thinking. Call on their experience to ensure you plan things in the

right way. Tap into their knowledge. Ask for their guidance on potential pitfalls. Use their positional power to get heard. Involving them from the kick-off can mean you're more likely to have their support going forward. People generally have a higher level of interest in both progress and outcomes when they've been involved from the start.

4. **Only consider the upsides? Think worst-case scenario.** In planning to get the balance right, think what could go wrong. Anticipate the obstacles before they appear. Part of preparing for things to go right with stakeholders is to think through what could go wrong. What's the worst possible scenario when it comes to balancing your stakeholders? Sponsors who don't buy into the benefits of your strategy? Team members who have no idea what's expected of them to execute on the plan? Peers caught off guard by how much time they must invest in your pet project? Customers blindsided by a large-scale change that impacts their own business? Power players who feel excluded from the decision-making process? Think about all that could go wrong, and then plan to get it right.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Giang, V. (2013, September 8). *How to win loyalty from others*. Business Insider.

Hack, N. B. (2011, May 3). How deeply engaging stakeholders changes everything. *Forbes*.

Kokemuller, N. (n.d.). How to deal with multiple stakeholders in organizations. *Chron*.

Springman, J. (2011, July 28). Implementing a stakeholder strategy. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

5. **Struggling with juggling? Prioritize.** Stakeholder groups can become very large, which will have an impact on your success in getting the balance right. You can't hope to give everyone the same level of attention, nor should you. You need to determine where to channel your energy and define the type of interaction you should have with each individual or group. Create an Influence/Interest grid—a 2X2 with "High to Low" axes describing the level of influence, or power, each stakeholder has, including their degree of interest. Classify each of your stakeholders. Use their position on the grid to determine how to interact with each of them. High Power/High Interest are the stakeholders you must manage most closely. Fully engage them and make the greatest effort to meet their needs. If you can't, explain why. High Power/Low Interest—keep them engaged, but don't bore them with too much detail. Low Power/High Interest—keep them adequately informed, but don't expend too much energy on them. Low Power/Low Interest—monitor them, but dedicate minimum effort. Keep in mind that influence and

interest can change due to a number of factors: role change, resource reallocation, other projects in the works, change in strategic direction. Keep alert to these changes and assess the effect they may have on your stakeholders. Keep your picture current.

6. Unsure how to involve stakeholders? Differentiate involvement. Involving everyone fully can become difficult to manage and slow down decision making. How actively involved should each of your stakeholders be? How do you decide how to balance involvement with just keeping them informed? Will they be on the periphery—on the outside looking in? Or will they be pivotal—at the hub of the action? It depends on a number of factors: The stakeholder's role and level of authority. The degree to which the project depends on their input. Their attitude toward the project. Supportive? They can be a great influence on others. Negative? On the one hand, they can derail, but on the other, you may want them where you can keep an eye on them—"Keep your friends close and your enemies closer." Consider these factors in your stakeholder analysis and categorize each individual or group's involvement: Essential—their input could make the difference between success and failure. Not involving them could cause issues with engagement and support. Optional—you can get there without their active contribution, but their involvement will make things quicker, easier, and more effective. Non-essential—others could contribute on their behalf. Make your assessment. Monitor progress. Adjust as needed.

7. Dealing with differing support? Manage collaborations. Your stakeholder group is a great resource. Leverage the power by

creating good connections and encouraging productive interactions. Make use of the differing viewpoints within the group. Assess people's attitudes and understand their points of view. Who will gain? Winners are likely to be positive. Who will lose? Those who are disadvantaged are more likely to be a challenge. Consider who has something that could be helpful to other stakeholders. Who has information? Facts and figures? Background details not readily available? Historical data? Establishing where people fall will help you decide who should communicate with whom. Who to group together in meetings concerning the project. Try to avoid your negative people having too much contact with each other. Mix your positive people with your negative people. Connect your dissenters with those who can help them see the benefits of the project. If someone has had a bad past experience that's tainting their view of the way forward, encourage their interaction with people who are open-minded and have a fresh outlook. Connect them with people who see the benefits and are not constrained by the past. If someone can't see the advantages of change, have them spend time with people who thrive on the new and different. Managing collaborations will help foster project success.

8. Out of sight, out of mind? Engage stakeholders near and far. It's easier to focus on stakeholders you come into contact with more frequently. Those you bump into at the water cooler. The people who attend the same meetings as you. But it's likely you have stakeholders at different locations. Those internal to the organization's home office or located in different regions. Externals like customers, the board, outside agencies. These may be the stakeholders who need more engagement but could end

up getting far less because of proximity. Beware the distance trap. Draw up a communications plan and stick to it. Make sure to include external stakeholders when you provide updates. Alert them to news that's relevant to the project and impacts them. Give them as much opportunity as possible to have direct contact with other stakeholders. Go see them at their own location.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Duff, V. (n.d.). How can stakeholders negatively influence a project? *Chron*.

Ernst, C. (2009, October 28). Leadership beyond bounds. *Forbes*.

Thompson, R. (n.d.). *Stakeholder analysis: Winning support for your projects*. Mind Tools.

- 9. Unhappy stakeholders? Listen to what matters to them.** Don't confuse being a stakeholder with being a supporter. Supporters emerge when they can see clear benefits from the project's success. Economic gain. Status improvement. An easier way to operate. Stakeholders can be non-supporters or resisters too. The strategy, once executed, will mean more work. Loss of relationships. Less security. Departure from something they know and are comfortable with. Understanding resisters' points of view is essential if you are to balance their concerns with the reality of what needs to happen. Chances are you won't be able to give them everything they want, but you can show that you empathize and recognize what's important to them. Make a point of understanding their concerns. Find out why they feel as they do. Understand the history that's driving their view of the future. Have they been here before? Have they had a bad experience with

something similar? Are they threatened by potential outcomes? What are they missing that could help them see the benefits of your direction? If they're going to lose out, how can you cushion that blow? They may never be your greatest advocate, but you can help them accept.

- 10. Conflicting viewpoints? Focus on strategy.** Stakeholders often have conflicting priorities and your challenge is to manage those. One person's loss can be another person's gain. A reduction in resources may mean cost savings for one stakeholder but a major execution challenge for another. A new process may mean more work for one team while effort is reduced in another. A change or variation in a product may be disappointing for one customer but exactly what the other customer is looking for. Start with empathy. Understand each point of view and recognize why their views are important to them. A rule of thumb in dealing with conflicting viewpoints is to try to find some common ground. In the case of your stakeholders, this may be difficult. Each likely has a solid rationale to back up their view. You need to be seen as objective and not playing favorites. So be impartial. Make it about the purpose, not about them. Show how the objectives of the project align with the strategic intent of the organization. Help them see the benefits more broadly than strictly how it impacts them. You may never get to a meeting of minds, but you can help them understand why you're doing what you're doing.

- 11. Once-and-done stakeholder planning? Monitor changes.** People change. Views alter. Priorities shift. Don't assume that where your stakeholders were when you first engaged with them is where they are now. You need to be on the ball and keep up-

to-date about stakeholder changes so you can modify your approach. Their role could have changed. Their position as a stakeholder may not be as influential. Perhaps they now have more power. Their interest level may not be what it was. Keep track. Stay in touch. Check the status quo when it comes to your stakeholders to ensure you understand their position. Don't make assumptions. Check in with them regularly. Take a temperature check on how they're feeling about things. What do they need more of? Less of? What's going on in their world that may affect their stakeholder position? Monitor continuously to keep balance in check.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Blanch, A. (2013, August 5). *How to manage difficult stakeholders*. Business Think Tank.

Hack, N. B. (2012, May 30). Improving stakeholder engagement increases productivity, profit and sustainability. *The Huffington Post*.

Merrett, R. (2012, July 31). Want project success? Engage stakeholders. *CIO*.

ProjectManager.com. (2013, November 11). *Project stakeholder communication tips*. Project Manager.

Job assignments

- Take on a project with a wide variety of internal and external stakeholders. Rise to the challenge of juggling priorities, preferences, and needs.

- Design a communications plan to inform stakeholders about a change that is not likely to be well-received.
- Get a group of stakeholders together who were involved in a recent project. Gather information from them regarding what worked well for them and what didn't.
- Present the strategic imperatives of the organization to your team, explaining where their efforts fit into the larger goals.
- Volunteer to rescue a project with unhappy stakeholders. Find out what's gone wrong. Engage them in moving forward in the right direction.

Take time to reflect...

If you focus purely on results and forget about people...

...then understand that stakeholders can help you get there faster, but they can also hold you back. Get them on board. Understand them. Engage them.

If you think that having a multitude of stakeholders will slow progress...

...then remember investing time up front can save you time later on. It's less about the number of stakeholders and much more about taking the right approach. The more stakeholders in your corner, the more your ideas will gain traction.

If you think you can predict what each stakeholder group needs...

...then tread carefully. Making assumptions can be dangerous and lead you down the wrong path entirely.

*"When one has so many different people
with different opinions to deal with in a new affair,
one is obliged sometimes to give up some smaller points
in order to obtain greater."*

Benjamin Franklin – American inventor, politician,
and one of the founding fathers of the United States



Learn more about **Balances** stakeholders

- Kuenkel, P., Gerlach, S., & Frieg, V. (2011). *Working with stakeholder dialogues*. Norderstedt, Germany: Books on Demand GmbH.
- Lewis, J. P. (2010). *Project planning, scheduling and control* (5th ed.). New York, NY: McGraw-Hill.
- Roeder, T. (2013). *Managing project stakeholders: Building a foundation to achieve project goals*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons, Inc.
- Shireman, B., Wohlgemuth, E., & Pfahl, D. (2013). *Engaging outraged stakeholders: How-to guide for uniting the left, right, capitalists, and activists*. New York, NY: Affinity Press.
- Walker, S. F., & Marr, J. W. (2001). *Stakeholder power: A winning plan for building stakeholder commitment and driving corporate growth*. Cambridge, MA: Perseus Publishing.



Deep dive learning resource links

- Blanch, A. (2013, August 5). *How to manage difficult stakeholders*. Business Think Tank. Retrieved from <http://www.businessthinktank.com.au/how-to-guides/how-to-manage-difficult-stakeholders>
- Duff, V. (n.d.). How can stakeholders negatively influence a project? *Chron*. Retrieved from <http://smallbusiness.chron.com/can-stakeholders-negatively-influence-project-36026.html>
- Ernst, C. (2009, October 28). Leadership beyond bounds. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/2009/10/28/boundaries-collaboration-teams-leadership-managing-ccl.html>
- Giang, V. (2013, September 8). *How to win loyalty from others*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://www.businessinsider.com/how-to-win-loyalty-from-others-2013-9>
- Hack, N. B. (2011, May 3). How deeply engaging stakeholders changes everything. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/85broads/2011/05/03/how-deeply-engaging-stakeholders-changes-everything/>
- Hack, N. B. (2012, May 30). Improving stakeholder engagement increases productivity, profit and sustainability. *The Huffington Post*. Retrieved from http://www.huffingtonpost.com/nadine-b-hack/stakeholder-engagement_b_1556070.html
- Kokemuller, N. (n.d.). How to deal with multiple stakeholders in organizations. *Chron*. Retrieved from <http://smallbusiness.chron.com/deal-multiple-stakeholders-organizations-62017.html>

Merrett, R. (2012, July 31). Want project success? Engage stakeholders. *CIO*. Retrieved from http://www.cio.com.au/article/432205/want_project_success_engage_stakeholders/

ProjectManager.com. (2013, November 11). *Project stakeholder communication tips*. Project Manager. Retrieved from <http://www.projectmanager.com/project-stakeholder-communication-tips.php>

Springman, J. (2011, July 28). Implementing a stakeholder strategy. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2011/07/implementing-a-stakeholder-str/>

Thompson, R. (n.d.). *Stakeholder analysis: Winning support for your projects*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newPPM_07.htm

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore *Balances* stakeholders further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Collaborating with stakeholders.
- Dealing with stakeholder conflict.
- How to identify your stakeholders.
- Managing difficult/challenging stakeholders.
- Project stakeholder communication.
- Stakeholder engagement.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



33. STRATEGIC MINDSET

Seeing ahead to future possibilities and translating them into breakthrough strategies.

Being strategic involves looking, planning, and moving into the future with clear intentions and purposeful actions. Some think being strategic is an either-or proposition—that a person is either tactical or strategic. Focused on the short-term or long-term. Interested in details or the big picture. While many people gravitate toward one side, a strategic mindset requires readiness for both. It's about doing things today with an eye toward tomorrow. Making decisions now that will lead the organization toward its future objectives. Like deciding where to invest to capitalize on emerging trends in your market. Like building internal capabilities that will help bring a new strategy to life. To develop a strategic mindset, you need to thoroughly understand the territory in which you operate. You need to understand what unique capabilities your unit or organization has to offer. You need to consistently ask where you are going and how you will get there.



"In strategy, it is important to see distant things as if they were close and to take a distanced view of close things."

Miyamoto Musashi – Japanese swordsman and samurai

Strategic mindset is in the **Thought** factor (I) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster C, **Creating the new and different**, along with Global perspective (18) and *Cultivates innovation* (19). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Anticipates future trends and implications accurately.**
- ★ **Readily poses future scenarios.**
- ★ **Articulates credible pictures and visions of possibilities that will create sustainable value.**
- ★ **Creates competitive and breakthrough strategies that show a clear connection between vision and action.**

Less skilled

- Is more comfortable in the tactical here and now.
- Spends little time or effort thinking about or working on strategic issues.
- Contributes little to strategic discussions.
- Lacks the disciplined thought processes to pull together varying elements into a coherent view.

Talented

- Sees the big picture, constantly imagines future scenarios, and creates strategies to sustain competitive advantage.
- Is a visionary and able to articulately paint credible pictures and visions of possibilities and likelihoods.
- Formulates a clear strategy and maps the aggressive steps that will clearly accelerate the organization toward its strategic goals.

Overused skill

- May be seen as too theoretical.
- May be so far ahead that others have trouble seeing how the organization will get from here to there.
- May be impatient with day-to-day tactical issues.
- May overcomplicate plans.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Strategic mindset. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Doesn't like complexity.
- Prefers what is familiar.
- Short-term focus.
- Lacks competitive drive.
- Overly tactical.
- Low curiosity.
- Too busy with today's tasks.

- Likes things to be predictable.
- Narrow perspective.
- Low-variety background.



Did you know?

A strategic approach to leadership is, on average, 10 times more significant to your perceived effectiveness than other behaviors. At least that's what a global survey of 60,000 managers conducted by the Management Research Group in 2013 found. Strategic-minded leaders tend to look much more broadly when they solve problems and make decisions. They think in multiple time frames, balancing achieving things now with planning for potential future outcomes. They think systemically, making connections and understanding the impact their decisions have on other parts of the organization. The study also revealed that those with the highest ratings on these skills associated with strategic mindset were four times more likely than their lower-scoring counterparts to be viewed as high potential within their organization.

Tips to develop Strategic mindset

1. **Can't anticipate what's to come? Become a trend-watcher.** Too busy getting today's work done to think about tomorrow? To cultivate a strategic mindset, keep one eye toward the horizon. Study emerging trends inside and outside your field. Get in the habit of questioning what things will mean for the future. How is technology driving greater efficiency and breakthrough innovation? How is social media altering the way people make purchasing decisions? Tap into future-focused resources such as

the World Future Society, Institute for the Future, or Faith Popcorn's TrendBank. Join the Future Trends group in LinkedIn. Listen to thought-provoking speakers live or online. Meet with colleagues to discuss how events and trends may impact your organization's strategy. Brainstorm ways you can capitalize on emerging opportunities. When examining trends, Rosabeth Moss Kanter advises zooming in and zooming out. Zoom in for sharp focus on important details. Zoom out to see how details form patterns and fit into the bigger picture.

2. Out of touch with customers? Make customer intimacy a priority. A winning strategy is designed around the customer. Understand your customers historically, today, and most importantly, tomorrow. What products and services do they want more or less of? How can you improve the user experience? What do your competitors offer that you don't? What trends do you need to monitor and plan for? Analyze market and customer data. Gather fresh insights. Watch customers as they interact with your products or services. Meet with your internal or external customers on a regular basis to understand their needs and desires. Determine which customers you want to keep and which you want to attract in the future. Plan how you'll accomplish these goals. Allocate your greatest resources to your primary customers.

3. Unclear about the competitive landscape? Get market smart. Know the industry inside and out, from the smallest to the largest player. Study the competition's annual reports, websites, press releases, social media sites. What are their strengths and weaknesses? What is their strategy related to speed, growth, customers, products/services, innovation, talent, and global

reach? How does their strategy compare to yours? Leverage knowledge about your similarities and differences to make better strategic decisions. Apply Michael Porter's Five Forces model to assess the intensity of the competition's power and the profitability of your industry. (*For more information, visit http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newTMC_08.htm.*) Spark conversations about how to anticipate the different moving parts in the marketplace. How might you best differentiate and keep your organization out in front?

4. Not standing out in the marketplace? Identify your distinctive advantage. A strategy is about what you do and what you want to become. It's also about what you don't do and do not aspire to be. No organization can be all things to all people. You have to make choices. Differentiation can take many forms. You can be a low-cost leader. Deliver quality products, services, or experiences. Or have superior customer relationships. A distinctive advantage is something that is hard for competitors to copy or develop. Spend time understanding your unique capabilities and offerings. Take a stand on what you'll continue to strengthen and promote in the future. Embed this strategy into the culture—employees of low-cost providers hunt for cost-savings; quality-first employees demonstrate an eye for detail; customer-service leaders treat everyone as special. Identify concrete ways to leverage what makes you distinct.

5. Developing a strategy in a vacuum? Scan the environment first. Before crafting a strategic plan, you need to get a handle on the context in which you operate. Pull together people with diverse knowledge and create a detailed picture. There are a

number of scanning frameworks you can use. The SWOT analysis (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats) is widely used to identify internal and external factors that define and shape a competitive position in the marketplace. A PEST analysis helps to capture the big picture in terms of Political, Economic, Social, Technological topics. (Some add Legal and Environmental.) Bennis and Nanus suggest using the Quick Environmental Scanning Technique (QUEST). In this framework, trends are observed, potential market conditions are forecasted, and options are discussed to address evolving conditions.

6. **Can't predict the future? Consider multiple scenarios.** It's not easy to develop strategic plans when faced with so many unknowns. Scenario planning can assist by generating useful dialogue and insights. It's not about predicting the future. It's about considering various possibilities. Discuss your assumptions about what might happen. Develop a small number of plausible scenarios (stories) about how the future might unfold. Think through how the organization could/should respond if faced with shifts in socioeconomic, political, technological, environmental, or social areas. Then do what expert Peter Schwartz calls "rehearsing the implications." How might things impact your industry, organization, stakeholders? What decisions would you need to make? What else might be triggered? What contingencies should be in place? Scenario planning makes you better prepared to recognize signals that warrant a response. And better able to anticipate, plan, and adapt when changes arise.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Edin, P., Lingqvist, O., & Tamsons, A. (2012, July 26). The best sales leaders are trend hunters. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Howes, L. (2012, December 11). 7 Steps to become an authority in your industry. *Entrepreneur*.

Straub, M. (2013, April 9). Does your business stand out in the marketplace? *The Business Times*.

7. **Think strategy is a waste of time? Recognize the value of strategy.** Some reject strategic work. They avoid it. They say they'd rather be doing something useful, like solving today's problems. That they've never seen a plan actually happen as projected anyway. While it's true that most strategic plans don't materialize as planned, that doesn't mean it was a wasted effort. A good strategy leads to practical decisions about what to do, who to hire, how to allocate funds and deploy resources. If you have doubts about whether to go ahead with a project, ask: Is this in line with our strategy? If you're wondering which option to choose, ask: Which best aligns with our key priorities? If your team is losing steam, ask: How will what we're doing now position us well for the future? A good strategy energizes people to move in the same direction. It makes choices clear and leads to less wasted effort.
8. **Looking for certainty? Embrace the unknown.** Strategic planning is one of the most uncertain things leaders do. It's speculating on the near-unknown. It requires projections into foggy landscapes. It requires making assumptions about

unfamiliar terrain. Many are uncomfortable making statements they can't back up with facts. Uncomfortable committing resources when there's no money-back guarantee. All adventures come with potential risks and rewards. Most strategies can be challenged and questioned. If you are questioned, think of it as a good thing. Questions from others are really opportunities to further vet your strategic direction. Questions raise issues you may not have thought of and likely yield a sounder approach as a result.

- 9. Consumed with daily demands? Make room for strategic priorities.** Burning issues require attention. It wouldn't be wise to ignore important demands of the day. Neither would it be wise to avoid what will matter most in the long run. You need to strike the right balance. Talk with colleagues to be sure you agree on what projects are mission critical vs. important vs. nice to have. If your team is engaged in activities that don't drive the strategy forward, make the case for discontinuing them. Create a culture of questioning. If people can't justify why something is important, they should question why it's on their plate. Reserve "thinking time" on your calendar to weed out distractions and make strategic adjustments.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Birshan, M., & Kar, J. (2012, July). Becoming more strategic: Three tips for any executive. *McKinsey Quarterly*.

Clark, D. (2013, October 8). What's keeping you from being strategic? *Forbes*.

Lester, A. (2012, December 7). More companies include retreat time to innovate. *The Boston Globe*.

10. Looking for some quick strategic wins? Play to your strengths.

Executing on your strategy may require that you and your team develop new skills. But that doesn't mean you should discount the strengths you already possess. Strategically smart organizations leverage their core capabilities. How can you build upon what is already great to drive your strategy forward? How can your talents' skills be applied more broadly? How can existing infrastructure be advanced? What products or services can be repurposed, redefined, or relaunched? Consider how you can take what's solid and extend it into new ventures. Disney's core is family-friendly entertainment. Over time, they extended their core beyond cartoons into theme parks, media, products, and retail, unlocking progressively more value. Consider how to capitalize on less obvious assets too—your intellectual property, materials, distribution networks, alliances.

11. Outdated strategic plan? Keep it fresh, fluid, and flexible.

It used to be that strategic plans were created once a year or every few years. They sat in binders on a shelf. Not today. To stay competitive and nimble, the neat and tidy plans of the past have been transformed into a continuous strategic planning process.

Make sure to revisit your strategy frequently. Debate key topics when they arise and focus on making sound decisions quickly. What are the mission-critical priorities? What key metrics will inform and guide you? Whose interests come first—customers, shareholders, employees? When difficult trade-offs surface, look to your core values to determine which way to go. Develop simple rules of thumb to guide people to make on-the-spot decisions, ensuring they stay aligned with the bigger picture.

12. Not sure how your role fits in? Identify a clear strategic line of sight.

Understanding strategy is important for people in every role. Learn about your organization's strategy. What primary objectives is it aiming toward? How does it plan to reach them? What critical capabilities and resources does the organization need to succeed? Talk about how your department supports or drives the organization's strategy directly or indirectly. How do you create value? Serve customers? Contribute to growth or the bottom line? Strengthen the brand? Support the community in which you operate? How do other functions build on the work your group produces? Spend time connecting the dots, and you'll have a better sense of what to emphasize in your daily work. If you can't demonstrate how a job aligns with the strategy, why do you have it?

13. Get tongue-tied when talking strategy? Learn to speak the language of strategy.

You may have a knack for thinking strategically but not know how to express it very well. Strategy is an emerging and ever-changing field. At any time, there are gurus who create new words and concepts to describe it. If you don't use these words, others may not perceive you as being strategic.

Learn from the latest experts. Watch their videos. Read their blogs and articles in the *Harvard Business Review* and similar publications. Read case studies about strategy and find parallels between other organizations and yours. Also pay attention to what your senior leaders are reading and talking about. Offer ideas on topics that match their strategic interests. Use the same terms and metaphors they use in their messages. Practice thinking and speaking more broadly than your own function and level. Go for form *and* substance.

14. Plans interrupted by unwanted change? Approach the future with optimism.

It's important to face undesirable realities—competitors disrupting the industry, regulators halting progress, unforeseen events crushing otherwise perfect plans. But doom and gloom forecasts do little to rouse energy and commitment. Make it a point to view needed changes in strategy with an optimistic lens. Reinforce your confidence in the resourcefulness, drive, and competence that you and your colleagues possess. It's hard to imagine new possibilities if you allow crises large and small to dampen your belief in a positive future. When change forces your strategy to change, regroup. Together, paint a new portrait of what's possible.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Green, H. (2012, September 11). Strategy ain't what it used to be. *Forbes*.

Hatch, J., & Zweig, J. (2001, March/April). Strategic flexibility – The key to growth. *Ivey Business Journal*.

Sirkin, H. L. (2013, September 23). The key to corporate fitness: Agility and flexibility. *Bloomberg Businessweek*.

Job assignments

- Take on a project or assignment that requires significant strategic thinking and planning with colleagues from various disciplines, divisions, or geographies.
- Prepare and present a strategic proposal to senior leaders that involves charting new ground. Identify the trade-offs inherent in any strategic decision.
- Do a thorough trend analysis and environmental scan of your function, unit, or organization as part of the strategic planning process.
- Manage an aspect of a rapidly expanding or growing operation that is instrumental to the organization's strategy.
- Conduct a competitive analysis of your organization's products/services and position in the marketplace.

Take time to reflect...

If you focus on the here and now...

...then understand that strategy is foresight. What got you here today will not get you there tomorrow. Keep one eye on the present, and focus the other on looking to the future.

If seeing ahead brings more fog than clarity...

...then recognize that a strategic mindset isn't about absolutes. Being curious and well-informed will help shed light on an uncertain future and make you more prepared for that future when it arrives.

If you see strategy as abstract and not concrete enough...

...then make your strategies solid. As you forecast what the organization can become, figure out what needs to happen along the way. Turn abstract goals into a tangible path to action.

"When you find a good move, look for a better one."

Emanuel Lasker – German chess player and philosopher



Learn more about Strategic mindset

Dranove, D., & Marciano, S. (2005). *Kellogg on strategy: Concepts, tools, and frameworks for practitioners*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.

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Magretta, J. (2011). *Understanding Michael Porter: The essential guide to competition and strategy*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Publishing.

Morgan, M., Levitt, R. E., & Malek, W. A. (2008). *Executing your strategy: How to break it down and get it done*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Publishing.

Porter, M. (1979). How competitive forces shape strategy. *Harvard Business Review*, 57(2), 86-93.



Deep dive learning resource links

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Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Strategic mindset further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Creating strategic flexibility.

- Implementing strategy.
- Learn more about your industry.
- Learn to be more strategic at work.
- Strategic adaptability.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.